Electronic Serials

H 1580.5

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A. Background

An electronic serial is a work in a machine-readable format, issued in successive designated parts for an indefinite period of time (that is, it meets the definition of a serial). It may be a remote access serial, such as those available on the Internet, or it may be a direct access serial, such as those issued on CD-ROM, flash drive, etc. This instruction sheet provides guidance on the assignment of subject headings to electronic serials.

LC practice: As stated in H 1075, LC catalogers will no longer use form subdivisions. For resources that would use form subdivisions, assign the LCGFT term appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand. For base instructions on assigning subject headings to serials, see H 178. For more detailed instructions on databases, see H 1520. For more detailed instructions on periodicals, see H 1927. For guidelines on assigning LCGFT, see J 243.

There is no need to express the electronic format via subject headings or genre/form terms. The format is carrier information expressed via descriptive cataloging values.

B. Recent revisions

2026-08: Updated template. Added alternative instructions for LCGFT implementation.

C. Definitions

Electronic serials: Serials in a digital format, such as PDF, epub, etc. May be digitized or born digital.

D. General rule

To an electronic serial, assign the appropriate heading(s) subdivided by the free-floating subdivision ***--Periodicals***. Do not further subdivide by ***--Databases*** to indicate that the serial is in electronic form.

LC practice: Assign the appropriate subject headings for the serial publication as a whole. Also assign the LCGFT term appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, i.e. LCGFT ***Periodicals***.

Examples:

```
Title: Electronic journal of differential equations.
   650 #0 $a Differential equations $v Periodicals.
LC practice:
   650 #0 $a Differential equations.
   655 #7 $a Periodicals. $2 lcgft


Title: TESL-EJ : teaching English as a second or foreign language : an
electronic journal.
   650 #0 $a English language $x Study and teaching $x Foreign speakers $v
         Periodicals.
LC practice:
   650 #0 $a English language $x Study and teaching $x Foreign speakers.
   655 #7 $a Periodicals. $2 lcgft
```

E. Databases that are updated

For databases that are regularly updated, follow the instructions in H 1520 Section D. Do not further subdivide by ***--Periodicals*** to indicate that the database is issued serially.

LC practice: For databases that are regularly updated, assign the appropriate subject headings for the topical focus of the data collected in the database. Also assign the LCGFT term appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, i.e. LCGFT ***Databases***. Do not consider the form to be a periodical.

Examples:

```
Title: Vietnam investment database.
```

[a database issued quarterly on CD-ROM.]

650 #0 $a Industries $z Vietnam $v Databases.

651 #0 $a Vietnam $x Commerce $v Databases.

LC practice:

650 #0 $a Industries $z Vietnam.

651 #0 $a Vietnam $x Commerce.

655 #7 $a Databases $2 lcgft

Title: Software information database.

[a database on computer software cumulated monthly.]

650 #0 $a Computer software $v Databases.

LC practice:

650 #0 $a Computer software.

655 #7 $a Databases $2 lcgft

Title: Counseling and therapy in video. Volume 1.

[a database of online videos updated quarterly]

520 ## $a An online video collection ... Spanning dozens of therapeutic methods, diagnoses, and cultural groups, this collection is essential for counseling and therapy programs across the curriculum-- in psychology, social work, education, nursing, divinity studies, health, and medicine. The material is clustered around easy-to-search and easy-to-browse topical subject areas and therapeutic methods: Addiction, Alcoholism, Brief Therapy, Cognitive-Behavioral Therapy, Group Therapy, Children and Adolescent Therapy, Couples and Family Therapy, Culture and Diversity, Domestic Violence, Existential/Humanistic Therapy, Gestalt Therapy, Gay/Lesbian/Bisexual/Transsexual Therapy, Narrative Therapy, Solution Focused Therapy, Supervision/Consultation, Career Counseling, and more.

650 #0 $a Counseling $v Databases.

650 #0 $a Psychology $v Databases.

650 #0 $a Psychotherapy $v Databases.

650 #0 $a Video recordings $v Databases.

650 #0 $a Educational films $v Databases.

LC practice:

650 #0 $a Counseling.

650 #0 $a Psychology.

```
650 #0 $a Psychotherapy.
655 #7 $a Video recordings $2 lcgft
655 #7 $a Educational films $2 lcgft
655 #7 $a Databases $2 lcgft
```

F. Serials about databases

For electronic serials whose subject matter is databases, follow the instructions in H 1520 Section H and add the free-floating form subdivision ***--Periodicals***.

LC practice: Assign the appropriate subject headings for the serial publication as a whole. Also assign the LCGFT term appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, i.e. LCGFT ***Periodicals***.

G. Reference type works

Do not assign the subdivision ***--Databases*** to electronic serials that have the structure of and present themselves as reference-type works such as bibliographies, catalogs, collections of abstracts, directories, dictionaries, indexes, or other similar types. Instead, assign the appropriate form headings or the appropriate subjects subdivided by the pertinent form subdivision. Further subdivide by ***--Periodicals*** unless the subdivision is one not further subdivided by ***--Periodicals*** according to the provisions of H 1927, sec. E. If one of these electronic serials is also a database, do not further subdivide by ***--Databases*** and do not assign an additional subject for the database. For guidelines to similar approaches for reference type works that are not serials, see H 1520 Section F.1.

LC practice: Assign the appropriate subject headings for the topical focus of the resource. Also assign the LCGFT term appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. LCGFT ***Telephone directories*** and ***Periodicals***. If the resource contains many different types of genre and/or forms, including one or more databases, consider the needs of specificity, according to J 110.

Example:

```
Title: The Sociofile database.
[a quarterly cumulation of abstracts from different sources in the
field of sociology.]
   650 #0 $a Sociology $v Abstracts $v Periodicals.
```

LC practice:

```
   650 #0 $a Sociology.
   655 #7 $a Periodicals $2 lcgft
   655 #7 $a Abstracts $2 lcgft
```

Title: Peterson's college selection service.

[a directory of U.S. colleges issued annually.]

650 #0 $a Universities and colleges $z United States $v Directories.

LC practice:

650 #0 $a Universities and colleges $z United States.

655 #7 $a Directories $2 lcgft

Title: Index to legal periodicals.

[a quarterly cumulative index to U.S. and foreign law periodicals.]

650 #0 $a Law $z United States $x Periodicals $v Indexes $v Periodicals.

650 #0 $a Law $x Periodicals $v Indexes $v Periodicals.

LC practice:

650 #0 $a Law $z United States $x Periodicals.

650 #0 $a Law $x Periodicals.

655 #7 $a Indexes $2 lcgft

655 #7 $a Periodicals $2 lcgft

H. Periodicals about databases on a topic

Assign headings of the type ***[topic]--Databases--Periodicals*** only to periodicals whose subject matter is databases on a particular subject.

LC practice: Assign the appropriate subject headings for the serial publication as a whole. Also assign the LCGFT term appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, i.e. LCGFT ***Periodicals***.

Example:

Title: CAD/CAM database strategies.

[a quarterly paper journal that deals with the design of CAD/CAM databases.]

650 #0 $a CAD/CAM systems $x Databases $v Periodicals.

LC practice:

650 #0 $a CAD/CAM systems $x Databases.

655 #7 $a Periodicals $2 lcgft

I. Databases of periodicals on a topic

For databases of periodicals on a topic, see H 1520 Section F.4.

Revision history

2026-08: Updated template. Added alternative instructions for LCGFT implementation.